AWS Log Search Recipes

2AM Incident Investigation Cheat Sheet

Use this quick reference during production incidents to decide which CloudWatch log searches to run first. The goal is not to read every log line — it is to identify patterns that quickly reduce uncertainty.

First Ask These Three Questions

- Is the failure global or limited to a subset of users?
- Is the failure getting worse, stable, or improving?
- Did something change recently (deployment, scaling event, config change)?

5- Minute Investigation Flow

Step	Recipe	Why Run It
1	Recipe 06 — Detect Error Rate Spike	Confirms whether errors truly increased and when the spike began.
2	Recipe 01 — Find the First Error	Identifies the earliest failure event before cascading symptoms appear.
3	Recipe 10 — Dependency Failures	Determines whether the incident originates from an external dependency.
4	Recipe 08 — Noisiest Tenant	Checks if the issue affects all users or only specific customers.
5	Recipe 09 — Trace Request Path	Reconstructs what happened to a request across services.

Key Insight

Most incidents are not solved by reading thousands of log lines. They are solved by running a small number of focused searches that reveal patterns hidden inside the noise.

Common Failure Patterns

- Cascading failures
- Dependency outages
- Retry amplification
- Resource exhaustion
- Configuration drift
- Partial deployments

Tip: If a search does not change what you would do next, stop running it and move to a different investigation path.